

What Bolivia reads: Pages, palabras and the stories in between

Addie Jones // Contributing Reporter // @addielizjones

SEO: Bolivia reading culture, literacy in Bolivia, education in Bolivia, indigenous languages Bolivia, Santa Cruz bookstores, Bolivia book fair, La Paz protests 2026, Bolivia education inequality, Bolivian literacy history, University of Arkansas study abroad Bolivia

Tease: Bolivia went from 36% illiteracy in 1976 to a literacy rate over 94% today, but packed bookstores and thriving book clubs in its major cities tell only part of the story.

Written for the "Multimedia Journalism & Art in Bolivia" study abroad program. Translation and interview assistance provided by Mariana Maira Ayala Gutierrez, a communication sciences student at the Universidad Autónoma Gabriel René Moreno. All interviews have been translated from Spanish to English.



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A street vendor organizes books in La Paz, Bolivia. The city's municipal library was locked the same day as nationwide protests shut down parts of the capital.

A handwritten cardboard donation box in San Pablo Café & Librería in Santa Cruz, Bolivia reads “un lector hoy, un líder mañana.” A reader today, a leader tomorrow.

"We have book clubs with more than 30 people each," said an anonymous employee. "There are people who even get turned away and have to wait for the next one. There is a reading community in Bolivia."

Bolivia has experienced one of the most dramatic literacy transformations of any nation in the Western hemisphere. While 36% of adults could not read in 1976, the country now has a literacy rate of over 94%, according to [Global Economy](#).

This progress is visible in bookstores and street stalls in major cities, but professors and researchers say urban Bolivia represents the best-case scenario. In rural Bolivia, some individuals counted as literate are only functionally literate, unable to meaningfully participate in employment or civic life.

Access to basic education drops from 98% in cities to 78% in rural areas, highlighting substantial gaps in infrastructure, according to the [SOLYDES Foundation](#), and more than a million Bolivians aged 15 and above remain illiterate or functionally illiterate, according to a [Ballard Brief study](#) on indigenous adult illiteracy in the Andean region.

What a country reads, and who gets to read it, tells a story of who it is becoming. Across 12 days and four Bolivian cities, the educational gap was present.



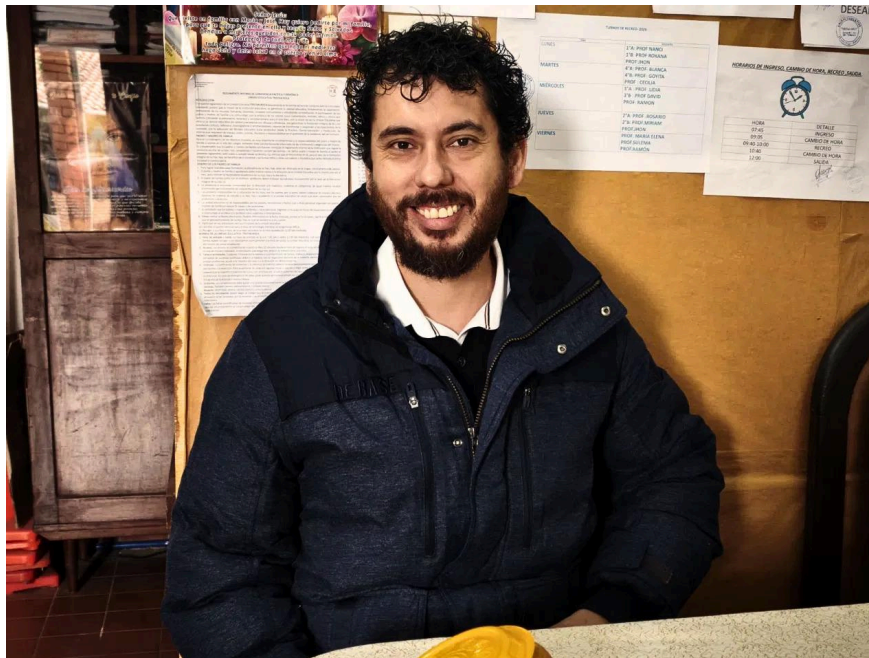
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A handwritten book donation sign at San Pablo Café & Librería encourages customers to share rather than keep their books. The Santa Cruz bookstore runs five book clubs a week, drawing more than 30 members each.

Santa Cruz is Bolivia's largest and fastest-growing city, boasting a confident relationship with books. Posters in several locations advertised the 27th Annual Feria Internacional del Libro, an international book fair running late May through early June. The tagline reads, "nos gusta leer." We like to read.

Inside the San Pablo bookstore, bookshelves stretch wall-to-wall, floor-to-ceiling. Genres span religion, philosophy, politics and children's fiction. A Virgin Mary stood between the titles, and a small printed card on a café table displayed an Aristotle quote: "El hombre es por naturaleza un ser que busca sentido. Man is by nature a being that seeks meaning."

John Willan Bejerano Cabrera, a computer science teacher working with students in Santa Cruz from preschool through high school, said the city's reading culture is growing, but slowly.



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John Willan Bejarano Cabrera sits at his desk, speaking about reading culture and education in Bolivia. Bejarano works with students ranging from preschool through high school in Santa Cruz.

“Santa Cruz doesn’t have a strong reading culture,” Bejarano Cabrera said. “Very few people have it. But it has been increasing over time. The best example is the Book Fair. Years ago, attendance was lower. It has been growing – not by leaps and bounds as we would like, but progressively.”

Sulema Medina Tapia, a sixth-grade teacher at a Santa Cruz primary school, agreed the fair represents a turning point.

“At the book fair you notice more people attending and buying a book,” Medina Tapia said. “They look for the book of their preference. A change is being seen.”

Bejarano Cabrera said most students do not get their books from bookstores and that “the vast majority use the markets.” Because market vendors do not issue official tax receipts, book prices are 10 to 15% lower, an important distinction for families with limited budgets.

Lidia Melgar Oliva, who teaches third grade at a Santa Cruz primary school, explained the difficulty of getting books into her classroom.



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Third-grade teacher Lidia Melgar Oliva stands in front of the chalkboard in her classroom. Melgar is navigating bureaucratic restrictions to incorporate supplementary reading materials into her curriculum.

"Right now, it is prohibited for teachers or school principals to sell any book or texts in schools," she said. "If we do that, we get reported and there are problems for us."

Melgar Olivia trained as a teacher from 2001 to 2004 during an era of education reform and has experienced decades of policy shifts. The changes do not just affect the curriculum, but also expectations for students and families.

She said when she studied and did homework at home as a student, she did not wait for her mom to help her.

"Why? Because there were punishments," Melgar Oliva said. "If you didn't do it, the punishment was carried out. So out of fear, you worked, you were responsible."

Technology has also played a mixed role in students' relationships with education and reading, she said.

"Before, I had to go to the public library," Melgar Oliva said. "I would take out the thick books and read. Now you give a child an assignment and the first thing they grab is their phone. Technology helps, but at the same time it hurts, because it no longer lets them learn to think."

Bejarano Cabrera said that if before, 5 out of 10 students did not read, the number has shifted to 8 out of 10 not reading.

"There is no love for reading among young Bolivians, and you cannot teach a love for reading," he said. "It has to be born. It is like watering a plant from a seed until it bears fruit. It is the parents who have to collaborate at home."

Bolivia's constitution officially recognizes 37 languages, and education laws have encouraged trilingual instruction in Spanish, English and an indigenous language, according to [Development and Cooperation](#).

In practice, however, indigenous languages are often treated as "transitional languages," with instruction reduced to the bare minimum and quickly replaced with exclusive Spanish.

"I teach the alphabet in English, I teach the alphabet in Guaraní," Melgar Oliva said. "Something basic, for knowledge."

It should be different, she said, but being in the city, there are very few places to practice indigenous languages.

In 2015, a team spent two years translating "The Little Prince," into Aymara, marking the first time this beloved novel existed in this indigenous language spoken by more than two million people across Bolivia, Peru and Chile. A Guaraní translation followed, making the story an unlikely tool of linguistic reclamation.



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A vendor at the Mercado Central in Uyuni holds up one of his favorite books for sale. Tables of books sit alongside clothes, watches and household goods at this large market on Calle 701.

Over 500 miles away from Santa Cruz, the high-altitude mining town Uyuni boasts the Mercado Central, bringing together vendors from surrounding small towns to sell anything ranging from calculators to soap and other household necessities.

Around a dozen vendors sold books, including one man who shared his favorite titles, encompassing topics like origami and soccer. Here, books are not packed on shelves or behind the class. They are practical goods, accessible to anyone with a few bolivianos.



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Melgar Oliva cautioned against this easy availability.

"They are good and bad at the same time," she said. "There are publishers that have closed. Since texts can no longer be requested, they are no longer used. Parents go to the cheaper texts, even if the content is not as good."

In a country where rural students complete an average of just 4.2 years of schooling, compared to 9.4 years for urban students, according to the [Borgen Project](#), the informal market is still a reliable point of access for many families to have books at all.



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Two young people sit outside the locked Biblioteca Municipal Mariscal Andrés de Santa Cruz in La Paz. The library was closed during nationwide protests demanding the resignation of President Rodrigo Paz in May 2026.

In May, year-long protests flared up and blocked off sections of Bolivia's administrative capital. Participants demanded the resignation of President Rodrigo Paz and blocked major highways into La Paz and El Alto, protesting inflation, fuel shortages and a deepening economic crisis.

The Biblioteca Municipal Mariscal Andrés de Santa Cruz, the main public library in La Paz, was locked early behind iron gates. Two young people sat on the steps outside, scrolling their phones. A planned bookstore route was blocked off entirely by ropes.

Despite the institutional barriers, books remained everywhere outside institutional walls. On a side street near the library, a woman in a pink coat arranged a floor-to-ceiling street stall of paperbacks, and on the sidewalk, someone had painted a mural of book spines into the concrete.



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La Paz has the lowest education inequality of any major Bolivian city, according to the [Sustainable Development Solutions Network Bolivia](#). Still, the city with the best-case scenario for literacy had it locked behind a gate.

"There are students who really put effort into learning, who would love for education to be different," Bejarano Cabrera said. "There is a lot of desire from many students who want to change, want to improve and want to leave behind the flaws in the country's educational system."

Medina Tapia, when asked what she would tell the world about education in Bolivia, kept it simple.

"We are on the right path," she said, "and we want to keep improving."